Taking a PPI Long Term: What to Know

PPIs (such as Prilosec, Nexium, Protonix and Prevacid) lower stomach acid. They work well, and many people need them for a long time.

Important	What about the risks?
Do not stop your PPI on your own. Ask your provider if you still need it.	Some studies link long-term use to broken bones, kidney problems and infections. They cannot prove the PPI is the cause, and stronger trials have not found more problems. Higher doses have stronger links.

If you...	What to do
Have severe acid damage to the esophagus, Barrett's esophagus, a high bleeding risk, or heartburn that always returns	Keep taking it. The benefits usually outweigh the risks.
Are not sure why you take it	Ask about lowering the dose or a trial off. Heartburn may come back for a few weeks. This is temporary.
Take it twice a day	Ask if you can drop to once a day.
Take it long term	Take it 30 to 60 minutes before a meal, use the lowest dose that works, and have it reviewed regularly. You do not need extra vitamins or routine blood tests just because you take a PPI.

Get care if you have	
Right away (call 911 for chest pain)	Black or bloody stools, vomiting blood, chest pain
Soon	Trouble swallowing, weight loss, severe diarrhea

General education only. Source: AGA 2022 guidance.